

Thomas J. Hughes

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Education

George Mason University

Fairfax, Virginia

Economics PhD Candidate, ABD

Expected Graduation: May 2027

MA Economics

Awarded May 16, 2025

Fields: Austrian Economics; Economic Sociology and Political Economy

Mercer University

Macon, Georgia

Bachelor of Arts, **Major:** Mathematics and Economics

Graduation: May 2023

Minor: Statistics

Certificate: Actuarial Science

Fellowships and Affiliations

PhD Fellowship, Mercatus Center

August 2023-present

Graduate Fellow, F.A. Hayek Program for Advanced Study in Philosophy, Politics, and Economics,

Mercatus Center

August 2023-present

Network Member, Initiative for the Study of a Stable Peace

January 2024-present

Professional Work

Graduate Lecturer (George Mason University)

August 2026-present

Course taught: Intermediate Microeconomics (ECON 306)

Graduate Teaching Assistant—Instructor of Record (George Mason University)

August 2025-May 2026

Courses taught: Four sections of Contemporary Macroeconomic Principles (ECON 104)

Course Evaluations:

Fall 2025: [Section 004](#); [Section 008](#)

Spring 2026: [Section 001](#); [Section 010](#)

Graduate Research Assistant (George Mason University)

August 2023-July 2025; August 2026-present

Assistant for Christopher J. Coyne during the 2023-2024, 2024-2025, and 2026-2027 academic years and the summer 2025 term.

Assistant for Peter J. Boettke during the summer 2024 term.

Preceptor (Mercer University)

August 2020-May 2021

Led four total sections of calculus 1 preceptor classes for the Department of Mathematics.

Published Papers

Bureaucratic Control After *Loper Bright Enterprises v. Raimondo*: The Rise of Judicial Control in a Post-Chevron Deference World (Journal of Public Finance and Public Choice, 2026. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1332/25156918Y2026D000000031>)

Under Review

The Weapon Itself is the Threat: Nuclear Weapons, the Knowledge Problem, and Normal Accidents (under review at Cosmos + Taxis; co-authored with Christopher J. Coyne, George Mason University)

The Budget-Maximizing Peacemaker: The Success Paradox of Peace-Through-Strength Defense Policy (under review at Public Choice).

Working Papers

Does Government-Nonprofit Contracting Instantiate Democratic Priority-Setting? (co-authored with Brian Mandeville, George Mason University).

Works in Progress

Papers

Centripetal and Centrifugal Forces in Single-Dimensional Computational Spatial Voting Models (co-authored with Robi Ragan, Mercer University)

Doctoral Failure: A Subjectivist Model of Exploitative Medical Behavior under Moral Constraints

When Truth Can Be Bad for Business: A Theory of Expert Failure in Religious Leadership (co-authored with Roger Koppl, Syracuse University)

William Niskanen and the Economics of Bureaucracy: Theory, Influence, and Policy Legacy

Books/Monographs

The Machinery of Administration: Bureaucracy in Mainline Economics (co-authored with Christopher J. Coyne; in progress)

Honors and Awards

Young Scholar, Association for Private Enterprise Education April 2026

Student Fellow of the Public Choice Society March 2026

Outstanding Award in Research, Stetson-Hatcher School of Business at Mercer University April 2023

Article: Centripetal and Centrifugal Forces in Single-Dimensional Computational Spatial Voting Models

Center for the Study of Economics and Liberty Research Grant, Mercer University January 2023

Article: Centripetal and Centrifugal Forces in Single-Dimensional Computational Spatial Voting Models

Professional Service

Referee

Journal of Public Finance and Public Choice

Invited Academic Presentations

Mercer University

Center for the Study of Economics and Liberty

September 10, 2026

Macon, Georgia

Lecture title: Peace Doesn't Pay: The Success Paradox of Defense Bureaucracy

Conferences

Association of Private Enterprise Education Meeting

April 5-7, 2026

Las Vegas, Nevada

Presented: The Budget-Maximizing Peacemaker: The Success Paradox of Peace-Through-Strength Defense Policy & The Weapon Itself is the Threat: Nuclear Weapons, the Knowledge Problem, and Normal Accidents

Public Choice Society

March 12-14, 2026

San Antonio, Texas

Presented: The Budget-Maximizing Peacemaker: The Success Paradox of Peace-Through-Strength Defense Policy

Southern Economic Association

November 22-24, 2025

Tampa, Florida

Presented: Bureaucratic Control After *Loper Bright Enterprises v. Raimondo*: The Rise of Judicial Control in a Post-Chevron Deference World & Doctoral Failure: A Subjectivist Model of Exploitative Medical Behavior under Moral Constraints

Markets and Society Conference

October 17-20, 2025

Falls Church, Virginia

Presented: The Weapon Itself is the Threat: Nuclear Weapons, the Knowledge Problem, and Normal Accidents

Society of Business, Industry, and Economics

April 12-14, 2023

Destin, Florida

Presented: Centripetal and Centrifugal Forces in Single-Dimensional Computational Spatial Voting Models

References

Christopher Coyne

Department of Economics

George Mason University

[ccoyn3@gmu.edu](mailto:ccoyne3@gmu.edu)

Rosolino Candela

Mercatus Center at George Mason University

rcandela@mercatus.gmu.edu

Peter Boettke

Distinguished University Professor of Economics and Philosophy

Department of Economics

George Mason University

pboettke@gmu.edu

Robi Ragan

Department of Economics

Mercer University

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